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Poetic Transformations of Narrative Discourse in an Amazonian Society

Recent studies of narrative in lowland South America have demonstrated that indigenous peoples from widely separate regions of the Amazon basin are capable of creatively reformulating their understandings of how the social order came into being and how it is situated and transformed, both by themselves and outsiders, in broader historical processes of change (Basso 1985; Chernela 1988; Guss 1986; Hendricks 1988; Hill and Wright 1988; Ireland 1988; Landaburu and Piñeda 1984; Piñeda 1985; Oostra 1988; Reeve 1988; Roe 1988; Turner 1988a, 1988b; Wright and Hill 1986). These studies of narrative construct theoretical approaches to history on the basis of indigenous concepts of power and modes of social consciousness. They have begun to show how indigenous peoples have created their own social and historical contradictions and developed collective strategies for impressing these contradictions into consciousness.

Narrative discourse is the best place to begin an analysis of indigenous concepts of social agency (see Basso 1985, for example, on the hierarchical levels of "animacy" and corresponding types of sounds embodied in Kalapalo narratives) and mythic and historical modes of social consciousness (see Hill, ed., 1988, for examples from several Amazonian and Andean societies). However, mythic and historical modes of social consciousness are not only found in narrative genres but are also embodied in closely related genres of poetic, ritual performance as well as in political oratory (see Alcida Ramos's and Terence Turner's analyses of indigenous political speeches to white audiences in Hill, ed., 1988). Indigenous modes of social consciousness are often better revealed through an approach that integrates the study of narrative and "extra-

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narrative" (e.g., musical, ceremonial, ritual, and political) genres of discourse rather than a narrow focus on narrative genres alone.

To demonstrate this point, I begin with a brief overview of the spatial-temporal transformations of bodily, social, and cosmic processes in the Wakuénai cycle of myths about Amáru and Kuwái, the primordial human mother and son. Next, I provide a glimpse of the ways in which these narrative metaphors are taken up in the poetic language of ritual chanting and singing. Finally, I return to consider how the Wakuénai have used the creative potentials of their myth-music nexus to reformulate their myth of autochthonous origins so as to accommodate the experience of domination by external, non-native peoples.

The transformational space-time of Amáru and Kuwái

At the most general level, the Kuwái myth cycle consists of two parts, or stages of creation. Part I of the cycle is concerned with psychosocial processes of development that unfold in parallel with a cumulative series of transformations in the vertical dimension of space-time in human society and the cosmos. This set of myths ends with the fiery death of Kuwái at the first initiation ritual and the contraction of the world back to its former size. Part II of the cycle focuses on the working out of the politics of gender relations in a patrilineal, patrilocal social order and the emergence of a horizontal dimension of exchange between separate peoples and places in the world.

Indigenous storytellers describe Kuwái as a monstrous, hairy being whose body consisted of all material elements and whose voice musically created the various species of animals and plants living in the Upper Rio Negro region. In part I of the narrative cycle, bodily processes of giving birth, fasting, vomiting, and eating serve as metaphors for the cumulative series of transformations leading from the presocial mythic past to a social world inhabited by fully human beings. The birth of Kuwái was an arduous passage from inside the maternal womb into the external world in which the father (Iñápirríkuli, the trickster-creator) and father's brothers called upon a series of animal helpers to open up a birth canal. Once outside the womb, the newly born child was immediately removed from the social space of Iñápirríkuli's village at Hípana to a house in the "corner of the sky" (*líwanápu éenu*). The father and father's brothers also placed a clay pot over Kuwái's mouth to muffle the sound of his voice. As the child of incestuous, animal-like sexual intercourse between Iñápirríkuli and Amáru, Kuwái at birth was a dangerous creature who had to be taken outside and above the world of mythic proto-humans at Hípana and whose voice had to be contained, or socialized. Thus, the initial passage from inside the maternal womb to the external world was paral-

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leled by the movement of Kuwái from inside to outside social space. The latter movement created a vertically separate "sky-world" (*éenu*), and the rest of part I of the myth cycle describes the progressive differentiation and mediation of this vertical distance between upper and lower worlds. Movements along the vertical dimension of mythic power metaphorically embody the social processes that unfold as individuals move between stages in the life cycle and between generations within the patrilineal descent group.[1]

In essence, the Kuwái myth cycle describes two transformations of body, society, and cosmos leading from the distant, presocial space-time of mythic beginnings at Hípana to the more recent, historical past of human beings in this world. The first transformation is a vertical opening up of the cosmos through the musical naming power of Kuwái's voice, or "the powerful sound that opened up the world" (*kémakáni hliméetaka hekwápi*). This raw, monological, musical, life-creating force must be brought *down to the ground* and *inside the social space* of the primordial human village at Hípana. Once this transformation has been completed, the life-giving powers of Kuwái are internalized into human social consciousness through Kuwái's teaching of *málikai*[2] songs and chants to Dzúli, the first chant-owner. The completion of the individual's socialization is overdetermined in myth as the destruction of the child (Kuwái) by the father (Iñápirríkuli) and father's brothers. After Kuwái has been pushed into a fire, the world contracts, or implodes, to its original, miniature size. The transformational power of Kuwái's fiery death is passed from outside to inside the body through the first initiate's licking hot pepper and eating the sacred food (*káridzámai*). The simultaneous implosion of the external world of animals, fish, and birds, and internalization of this newly miniature world in the form of *káridzámai* into the body of the first initiate marks the completion of the series of transformations leading to a reversal of the initial movement from inside-to-outside Amáru's womb. Kuwái's vertical opening up of body, society, and cosmos is now turned upside-down and inside-out.

The second transformation of body, society, and cosmos is a horizontal opening up of the world. Kuwái's ashes turn into the plant materials from which men make the sacred flutes and trumpets for *kwépani* (Kuwái-dance) and for performing the power of ancestral spirits in male and female initiation rituals (*wákapétaka yénpitipé*, or "we show our children" and *wakáitaka yénpitipé*, or "we speak to our children," respectively). These plant materials, and in particular the *macanilla* palm used to make the resonating chambers of Kuwái's flutes and trumpets, are the starting point of a second creation, or regeneration, of the world. In the myth, Iñápirríkuli orders a squirrel to climb the

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macanilla palm and mark off sections of different length. The standing palmtree embodies the structure of the cosmos after Kuwái's fiery "death," or transformation: the sky-world of mythic ancestors is both connected to the terrestrial world of humans and animals and insulated, or differentiated, through the squirrel's markings. These sections of palmwood will become the flutes and trumpets representing animal species and parts of the body of Kuwái in sacred rites and ceremonies. In this new form, Kuwái is no longer an autonomous, individual being whose voice independently creates the world, but an assemblage of material objects that must be actively constructed and played by groups of people.

In the myth, the completion of Kuwái's transformation from an individual being into an ensemble of musical instruments comes about when Iñápirríkuli strikes the base of the macanilla palm with a long stick. The palm breaks at each of the places where the squirrel had marked it and falls in a pile of logs.[3] Whereas in part I of the myth cycle, Kuwái was a weightless, flying creature who had to be gradually coaxed, or tricked, into coming down to his "death" at Hípana, in part II of the myth cycle Kuwái has weight that can come crashing down upon people below. The downward motion of the macanilla logs in myth turns the first creation of the world, or the coming-into-being of a vertical, hierarchical structure of generations and developmental stages that are poetically mediated by specialists in performances of málikai, inside-out and upside-down. The weight of this power structure comes tumbling down when Iñápirríkuli strikes the base of the macanilla palm with a long stick.[4] The horizontal distance between Iñápirríkuli and the falling logs is the difference between life and death. The regeneration of life through making and playing musical instruments is only possible because Iñápirríkuli stays at a safe distance from the falling logs. This horizontal space becomes the prototype of the opening up of a world of socially and geographically separate peoples and places in part II of the myth cycle.

At the same time, the vertical dimension of mythic power has been totally inverted, or turned upside-down. The rising and falling of Kuwái in the form of a palm tree replicates in a single episode the entire series of transformations that developed in part I of the myth cycle. The "up-above and outside" is now the "down on the ground and inside," and the transformations of space-time in the second part of the myth cycle outline a process of reversing the initial situation of Kuwái falling down to the ground (in the form of logs) into its opposite, or the final departure of Kuwái from the ground at Hípana up to the "corner of the sky" (*líwanápu éenu*). The inversion of internal and external space results in a shifting of focus from physiological processes in which foods, bodies, and other substances move across the boundaries of mythic bodies, to

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social processes in which groups of men and women make and play musical instruments while going from one place to another, and, in doing so, create an external world consisting of distinct peoples and places. In other words, the world of Kuwái's first creation has been turned inside-out: internal bodily processes are turned outwards to create an anthropomorphized, musicalized, ritual world of peoples who exchange goods and persons across social boundaries, all within the context of an overarching vertical hierarchy of power relations between mythic ancestors and human descendants.

The clearest examples of this turning inside-out of Kuwái's first creation are the sets of málikai songs and chants performed at male and female puberty initiations. In the opening málikai song for initiation, chant-owners invoke the names of the mythic places where Iñápirríkuli, Kuwái, and Amáru live in the sky and musically bring these mythic beings down into the initiates' sacred food (*káridzámai*) through naming the celestial umbilical cord (*hliépule-kwá éenu*). Movements between distinct tones, or pitches, within the opening song for initiation are a breakthrough into sung speech that embodies within itself the principle of movements between vertical regions of the cosmos and developmental stages within human society. Midway through the opening song for initiation, the singing transforms into tonally flat, chanted speech. In the long set of chants that follows, chant-owners name all the edible species of plants and animals as they poetically follow Amáru on her mythic journey away from and back to the center of the world at Hípana. A closing song returns to the same pitches used in the opening song to musically create the celestial umbilical cord linking mythic ancestors to the newly regenerated world of human descendants. In these ritual performances, the turning inside-out of Kuwái's first creation is concretely embodied in the uses of sung and chanted speech to musically connect the expanding "world-body" to the nurturing, mythic ancestral powers of the sky-world.

In part II of the Kuwái myth cycle, the transformation of horizontal space, or the creation of a collectivity of "we people here" who are distinct from "those other peoples there," is depicted as a struggle between men and women. In the context of a patrilineal, patrilocal social world, women are inextricably associated with change and otherness, and gender consciousness becomes the seed of a historical consciousness of changing relations between peoples, or descent groups (*náiki*). Amáru and the women take control over Kuwái's flutes and trumpets, but they can do so only by going away from Hípana to other places downstream. The mythic situation of the women is thus analogous to the social situation of newly initiated girls (*wálimerú*) who are initiated into the

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local ancestor cult only to be excluded from it upon reaching full adulthood and going to live in their husbands' villages. In the final myth of the cycle, Iñápirríkuli and the men take the flutes and trumpets back from Amáru and the women by knocking them unconscious with a bolt of lightning. Through this imagery, the ambivalent situation of the individual female initiate's simultaneous inclusion in and exclusion from her patrisib is transformed into a collective process of "death," or loss. The individual death, or loss of menstrual blood, by newly initiated girls is ultimately experienced as a collective loss of female blood-kin by wives' kin groups to husbands' kin groups. The myth portrays this collective loss as a simple gender opposition between adult men and women. Analysis, however, reveals that the horizontal dimension of exchange is actually a more complex social confrontation between descent groups whose members include both male and female descendants of the local ancestor spirits.

In effecting the collective "death" of Amáru and the women and bringing them inside their social world, Iñápirríkuli and the men have internalized the ambivalent inclusivity/exclusivity of the horizontal dimension of exchange relations between descent groups. The women who are contained inside a ceremonial house by men in kwépani encompass both the inclusion of other peoples' female kin and the eventual exclusion of their own people's female kin. By internalizing the simultaneous gain and loss of female blood relatives through exchange, the men, disguised as animals, embody an alienated consciousness of themselves as *other peoples' others*. In the final episode of the myth, Iñápirríkuli teaches men how to construct the enormous, *dzáwinápa* (jaguar-bone) trumpets of the ancestors, thus allowing men to negate their alienated consciousness of being "other peoples' others" and enabling Kuwái and Amáru to depart for the sky worlds.

In the two parts of the Kuwái myth cycle, the Wakuénai construct two contrasting views of their social world and its relations to the inner world of bodily experiences and the outer world of non-human animal nature. The first perspective on human social relations is that of the child's internal, bodily experiences of birth, separation from the parents, and self-empowerment through ritual fasting and eating the sacred food (*káridzámai*). The socialization of individual, bodily processes in children is a process of mediating and constructing a vertical dimension of space-time, or the opening up of a cosmic structure of upper and lower worlds and a power structure of ancestors, ritual specialists, and descendants. In this internal view of the social world, the child's experience of socialization is also defined along the vertical dimension of space-time as a movement down from the initially natural status of newly born infant

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(*kérramu*), through the various intermediary transformations of the semi-socialized child (*yénpiti*), and down to the ground as a fully socialized, initiated young adult (*wálitáki*, or "newly fasted"). With the eating of fully socialized nature, or the sacred food (*káridzámai*), the child's internal perspective of social reality has reached completion, and not a single reference to the first initiate is made throughout the entire second part of the narrative cycle.

The social processes of exchange, or inclusion and exclusion, that open up along the horizontal dimension of space-time in part II of the Kuwái myth cycle are inherently collective processes of integration and separation among peoples, or descent groups, from different places. They cannot be reduced as in part I to the level of the individual's socialization. The disappearance of Hérri, the first socialized individual, from the sequence of narratives in part II of the myth cycle concretely expresses the irrelevance of the individual level of experience for the development of collective institutions, such as bride service, exogamy, and patrilocal residence. As Turner noted in his analysis of a Kayapó creation myth, the story of the proto-human individual's socialization implies that there must be another story about the coming-into-being of the family structures into which the individual has been socialized: " . . . namely, how the collective form of human society arose from the dispersal of an individual domestic family, and how the collective institutions in turn established the pattern for the reproduction of all future families" (1985:95). For the Wakuénai, part II of the Kuwái myth cycle answers these questions by showing how the individual experiences of young, newly initiated men and women are transformed into collective processes of inclusion and exclusion among a plurality of intermarrying descent groups, or peoples. Part II of the myth cycle demonstrates how a single descent group was opened up to produce a world consisting of a collectivity of "we people here" and a contrasting plurality of social others, or "those peoples there." In doing so, the second part of the Kuwái myth cycle also establishes the pattern for reproducing the plurality of social others through the negation of a people's alienated consciousness of themselves as "other peoples' others."

The child's internal view of social reality as a process of becoming human and the adult's external view of it as the collective reproduction of descent groups form two contrasting perspectives that are defined relative to one another in the Kuwái myth cycle and yet cannot be reduced to mere reflections of each other. In the final analysis, to control social reproduction, or the formation of descent groups through exogamous exchanges of male labor and female blood relatives, is a more dynamic and powerful process than the intra-descent group process of the individual's socializa-

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tion. However, these two hierarchical levels of power relations are mutually defining, since the more dynamic processes of social reproduction embodied in part II of the narrative cycle are themselves a product of the transformation, through turning upside-down and inside-out, of the socialization of Kuwái and the first initiate in part I of the myth cycle. This double perspective upon Kuwái's two openings of the world constitutes the highest level of mythic meaning, or the symbolic mediation of the social contradiction between the individual's socialization and the collective reproduction of descent groups.

The poetics of ritual power

Before going on to discuss the mediation of temporal relations in málikai, it is important to reiterate that spatial movement, or expansion, is basic to the nature of Wakuénai ways of thinking about the past. The spatial movements of Kuwái and Amáru in the primordial human past are not described as mere journeys between places that already exist but as a dynamic process of creating spatial distances between places. The narratives do not arrange the space inhabited by the Wakuénai phratries of the Isana and Guainía rivers into a "mythic timeless order"; rather, they describe that space as a dynamic, temporal process in which an earlier, space-less time preceded the growth of the world in primordial human times. The transformational space-time of Kuwái and Amáru separates the mythical Beginning at Hípana from the human past, resulting in a tripartite temporal framework, which is in turn matched by a tripartite division of the cosmos into the world of living human beings (*hekwápiríko*), the dark netherworld (*íyarudáti*) of recently-deceased persons (*lidánam*, or "shadows"), and the celestial paradise (*likáremi*) of Iñápirríkuli. Thus, when the Wakuénai speak about earlier and later past times, they are also speaking about places and spatial movements. Conversely, the way in which the Wakuénai speak about and enact past times is most often accomplished through metaphors of place and spatial movement.

Wakuénai ritual language (málikai) differs from the dialects of everyday speech in several important ways. Although all native speakers can recognize the literal meanings of many words in málikai, only the specialists, called *málikai limínali* (málikai "owners," or chant-owners), know all the nuances and allusions to narrative episodes condensed into the spirit-names of Kuwái. The activity of performing málikai is called *ínyapakáati* and refers minimally to a voiced, aspirated exhalation of the breath made visible by tobacco smoke (see Hill 1985). Spirit-naming in málikai is thus more than a simple verbal act and entails the audible, visible releasing of spirit-names as musical tones. In talking about máli-

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kai, chant-owners have little more to say about these musical sounds than that they are *kémakáni hliméetaka hekwápi*. In contrast, they are extremely articulate in speaking about the language of málikai (i.e., the spirit-names themselves). Basically, all spirit-names in málikai have two parts, or identities, one generic and the other specific. The double identity of beings named in málikai has its origins in the primordial human being, Kuwái, who describes himself in narratives as "all things in this world" (*phiúmi hekwápiríko*).

In linguistic terms, málikai contains a system of generic classifiers in which each specific object, species, or person is categorized in one or more generic noun class. The principle of generic classification is capable of expressing profoundly contradictory images of the mythical figure of Kuwái. On the one hand, the chant-owner can enact Kuwái's vertical creation of the world by placing emphasis on generic categories which include many distinct individuals, species, and objects into a single compound entity. This process, called "heaping up the names in one single place" (*wakétaka nakúna papínirítsa*), is a relatively simple technique of naming a generic class of spirits and then filling it up (*wakámtaka nakúna*) with specific names. On the other hand, the chant-owner can juxtapose a variety of different generic names, each with a complementary, specific name, to enact Kuwái's second, horizontal creation of the world. The result of this process, called "chasing after the names" (*wápinétaka wátsani nakúna*), or "going in search of the names" (*wápinétaka wadzúhiakáw nakúna*), is a dynamic montage of unique metaphors highlighting the uniqueness of specific spirit-names which exclude all but a single individual, species, or object on the basis of distinctive qualities.

In childbirth rituals, for example, the chant-owner uses a variety of auditory, tactile, and visual imagery in searching for the tobacco spirits of a newborn infant's mythic ancestors. The spirit-names connect the everyday world of tools, weapons, and objects of the father's work activities to the hyperactive, undifferentiated musical naming power of Kuwái, or "the powerful sound that opened up the world." The spirit-name for *pwáapwa*, a palmwood species that men use for weaving baskets and other products, is *límutukéku éenu*, or "the ripping sound of the sky," referring to the ripping, tearing sound produced when the outer bark of the tree is peeled off to make thin strips of weaving material. *Éenu* means "sky" in everyday speech, but in málikai chants éenu is a category of spirit-names that includes various species of wild palms that are sources of useful material and/or edible fruits. Palm trees have a broader mythic significance as the reincarnation of Kuwái after his fiery "death." As the vertical pathway between the celestial world of mythic ancestors and the

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social world of human descendants on the ground, palm trees form a cosmic umbilical cord that nourishes humanity with life-giving ancestral powers. This connotation of the term éenu is expressed in the spirit-naming of pwáapwa palms which, like other important species or objects, receives more than one spirit-name in málikai.

Wádewátsa liákan, likaíteri límutukéku éenu,
So that no harm is done, the name of the ripping-sound sky-spirit is spoken,

Likáiteri lítiekúka éenu,
The name of the cutting smooth sky-spirit is spoken,

Líkapáni hliépulepukúke éenu,
The navel of the sky, the manioc sieve, is looked upon,

Wádewátsa línakúka líkanúpa límidzáka ikérramuléna,
So that no harm is done to the newborn infant,

Nuáwa lidákiwa mánupánam dzéema.
I give for his body that-has-no-danger tobacco.

Like the spirit-names for sharp, cutting tools, the second spirit-name for pwáapwa, *lítiekúka éenu,* associates the smooth, thin strips of weaving material with cutting and loss of blood. The third name relates pwáapwa, the material for making manioc sieves, to an anthropomorphic image of the cosmos as a "body" linked to the celestial world of ancestor spirits through a "navel" at the center of the world, or Hípana. Thus, in the space of one short stanza, the chant-owner synaesthetically interweaves auditory, tactile, and visual images of mythic power to verbally construct the pwáapwa palm as a ripping-sound, cutting-smooth, cosmic navel of the human universe.

The two processes of spirit-naming in málikai, "heaping up" and "searching for the names," are semantic expressions of a relative hierarchy of structural levels that pervades Wakuénai sacred myths and rituals. "Heaping up the names," or categorizing specific objects, species, and individuals into generic classes, is a taxonomic principle which defines a lower-level pattern of relations. "Heaping up the names" is a classificatory operation in which the natural, social, and mythical worlds are organized into relatively discrete, bounded semantic classes, each of which is analogously constituted with all the other classes through the generic-to-specific relationship. The more dynamic process of "searching for the names" operates against the relatively static taxonomic principle of "heaping up the names" into discrete categories.

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"Searching for the names" is essentially a process of transferring spirit-names which are exceptionally powerful or harmful from the generic class to which they would belong according to the lower-level, taxonomic principle into a different class of names on the basis of mythical connections. For example, in the process of "heaping up" the spirit-names of edible bird species for the food of a newborn infant's parents, the chant-owner names the yellow curassow in the class of *umáwari*, or fish and aquatic animal species. The reason for this shifting of a bird species to the class of aquatic species is that in myth the yellow curassow transforms itself into an anaconda. The higher-level process of "searching for the names" is thus a mythic principle of semantic transferral which overrides the lower-level, taxonomic principle of "heaping up the names."[5]

In any given performance of málikai, chant-owners make use of both taxonomic and mythic principles, but one or the other of the two principles is dominant. The relation between higher- and lower-levels is not an absolute opposition between dynamic and static but a relative contrast of more to less dynamic. "Searching for the names" is a semantic expression of transcendence through which processes of change, reordering, and transformation are given symbolic form. "Heaping up the names" is an expression of the basic order from which meaningful change and transformation arise (see Hill 1985 for a more detailed account of these naming processes and their projection into musical processes).

The poetic transformation of narrative discourse

The hierarchy of mythic and taxonomic principles enacted in málikai and the transformational space-time described in narratives about the primordial human past of Kuwái and Amáru have become a basis for interpreting the history of Indian-white relations. As a mode of historical consciousness, Wakuénai ritual language and narratives do not form an atemporal structure of "conventional meanings" that absorbs or freezes the events of Indian-white history into a "mythic timeless order." The Wakuénai do not see themselves as the passive reactors to events initiated by the whites or as recipients of the whites' culture. Instead, the white men and their culture are classified through the taxonomic principle of ritual language so that they can be understood in relation to the more dynamic mythic principle of "searching for the names." In what amounts to nearly a reversal of the "cold" versus "hot" society distinction in structuralist anthropology (Lévi-Strauss 1962), the Wakuénai interpret the white men as a "heaped up pile of souls" who are less dynamic (though not totally static) than the Wakuénai and neighboring indigenous societies of the Northwest Amazon region, who possess powerful sib

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names, or souls, which must be "searched for" anew in each generation. Through the complex of narratives and ritual language outlined above, the Wakuénai view themselves as the principal makers and keepers of a sacred regional history, which subsumes the origins of the white men and their culture in the Upper Rio Negro region.

The following version of the myth of sib ancestor emergence comes from a Dzawinai chant-owner of the lower Guainia river in Venezuela (Hill, field notes). The bulk of his narrative consists of a simple listing of Wakuénai sib names and their corresponding male and female tobacco spirits. Excluding the list of names in "brackets," the narrative is reducible to the following underlying sequence of actions:

> 1. The white men were the first people to emerge from the hole beneath the rapids at Hípana, and Iñápirríkuli gave them all a single name (*yárinárinái*) and tobacco spirit (*Hérri hálepiwánai iénipe*). "Later we will go to search for the names (*nanáikika*) of these people," explained the trickster-creator.
> 2. Iñápirríkuli searched for the names of all the Wakuénai sibs and gave them each a pair of tobacco spirits.
> 3. After giving names and spirits to all the Wakuénai sibs of the Isana and Guainía rivers, Iñápirríkuli continued to search for the names of Arawakan and Tukanoan groups of the Vaupés (Tariano, Uanano, and Cubeo). Although these groups formed part of the same search for sib names by Iñápirríkuli, they are distinguished from Wakuénai sibs by the phrase "after the white men" (*hnetédali yárinárinái*).
> 4. Iñápirríkuli ran out of names, for "there were too many people" (*néni nétim yúhakawa*). "Let's heap up these people and give them the spirit-name *liwakétanhim dzáwinápirríkuli* (the heap or pile of Iñápirríkuli)." Iñápirríkuli gave the white men the name *yárinárinái*, and he named the places where they were to live Colombia, Venezuela, and Brazil.

In this narrative, the relative hierarchy of semantic principles in málikai becomes a means for giving cultural form to an indigenous interpretation of the history of Indian-white relations in the Upper Rio Negro region. The arrival of the white men is not expressed as a passive experience that "happened to" the Wakuénai but as part of the same active process through which Iñápirríkuli, the trickster-creator, brought into being the ancestral spirits of the Wakuénai. The trickster-creator raised the white men's ancestors from the ground at Hípana before raising the sib ancestors of the Wakuénai and other indigenous groups, but he did

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not give the white men powerful sib names that must be actively "searched for." Iñápirríkuli announced his intention to search for the sib names of the white men later, after searching for those of the Wakuénai and their neighbors. As is so often the case in narratives about Iñápirríkuli, the trickster-creator's words and deeds are in the final analysis shown to be clever deceptions which must be interpreted rather than taken at face value. In the final episode of the narrative, when Iñápirríkuli has run out of names because the white men were too numerous, the real intentions of the trickster-creator are revealed: to heap up the white men as *liwakétanhim* (heap or pile) rather than to search for their sib names (*nanáikika*). This denouement makes explicit the contrast between higher- and lower-level naming principles and the analogous contrast between indigenous peoples (*hwá nawíki*) and the white men (*yinárinái*). The contrast is not a simple binary opposition of the Lévi-Straussian sort (i.e., Indian : white :: dynamic : static) but a continuum of more-to-less dynamic.

In the concluding episode of the narrative, Iñápirríkuli runs out of names because there are "too many people," and he names the places where the white men are to live: Colombia, Venezuela, and Brazil. The indigenous view of history presupposes smallness of social scale, but not rigidity. Sib names for several indigenous societies of the Upper Rio Negro region are added to Iñápirríkuli's search "after the white men," but the white men themselves are simply too numerous to include into this mythical process. The trickster-creator does, however, name the places where the white men are to live. Given the central importance of spatial movements and the naming of places in Wakuénai ways of thinking about the past, Iñápirríkuli's naming of white men's places is better understood as a metaphor of the active creation of an historical space-time which the Wakuénai have shared with the white men for the past 250 years rather than a static, atemporal arrangement of space into a mythic order. The division of Wakuénai ancestral lands among Brazil, Colombia, and Venezuela was an historical process of great significance to the Wakuénai, for the spatial movements back and forth between river systems has been a key strategy for coping with the white men's diseases, economic oppression, military force, and missionary activity. Whereas the Wakuénai understand their history as a balanced relation between the rivers and forests which they inhabit today and the dynamic transformations of the closed world of the mythical Beginning at Hípana during the primordial human past of Kuwái and Amáru, the white men have struggled since the time of their arrival in the eighteenth century to divide the Upper Rio Negro region into separate administrative spheres of control. For the Wakuénai, it is the white men and not indigenous

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peoples who have treated their territory and its inhabitants as cold, ahistorical, and lifeless abstractions open to instrumental manipulations.

Conclusions

In transforming their narrative of collective, mythic origin from the ground at Hípana, the Wakuénai have taken the poetic mediation of the contradiction between vertical (developmental-generational) and horizontal (political-historical) dimensions of space-time from the ritual language of málikai songs and chants and integrated it into a narrative discourse that comments upon and socializes the macabre history of interethnic relations in the Upper Rio Negro region. The whites are simultaneously included and excluded into the bodily, social, and cosmic worlds created by Kuwái. Whereas the final narrative of the Kuwái myth cycle is about the negation of a people's alienated consciousness of being "other peoples' others," the transformed version of the myth of autochthonous origins is concerned with negating the alienated consciousness of the Wakuénai as being "the whites' others," or unwilling, coerced victims of political-economic domination and the culture of terror during the rubber boom and earlier, colonial periods (see Wright 1981; Wright and Hill 1986; Hill and Wright 1988).

The dynamic interrelations between mythic discourse and ritual performances of the Wakuénai have far-reaching implications for contextual studies of indigenous South American discourse. The gap separating mythic discourse from ritual performance allows room for creativity, improvisation, and the emergence of novel interpretations as well as for the passing down of knowledge from ancestors to descendants. The metaphorical processes of mythic discourse do not exist as a frozen stockpile of concepts forming a rigid, logical order but are actively put to the service of collective thought and action in narrative performances that are themselves socially situated, sensuous expressions of verbal artistry. Moreover, these narrative constructions of mythic creation can stimulate the search for new metaphorical relations in nature, society, and history through asserting the primacy of dynamic transformations over categories or states of being.

For Wakuénai chant-owners, the twin processes of "heaping up" and "searching for" spirit-names are poetic tools for exploring the diversity of natural species and social beings as a mythic palette of colors, shapes, sounds, textures, temperatures, and emotions. "Searching for the names" is a concrete expression of the musicality of spoken and chanted speech and a virtuoso display of poetic creativity. "Heaping up the names" gives poetic form to the classificatory power of mythic speech, its capacity to facilitate the arts of memory and the continuous passing down of power-

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ful knowledge from ancestors to descendants. Historical interpretation emerges from the interplay between poetic creativity and mythic imagination, between "searching for the names" across the cultural landscape and "heaping up the names" in a single place.

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NOTES

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1. This analysis of vertical mythic space as a metaphor for specific types of social time builds upon Turner's pathbreaking study (1985) of a Kayapó creation myth.

2. *Málikai* is a complex genre of spoken, chanted, and sung speech performed only by specialists, called *málikai limínali* (chant-owners) during rites of passage, curing rituals, and a variety of less formal contexts. For a detailed analysis of the two sets of málikai chants performed in childbirth rituals, see Hill (1985).

3. This is yet another of Kuwái's unsuccessful attempts to kill Iñápirríkuli. The trickster theme continues throughout the Kuwái myth cycle just as it does in myths about the primordial past and more recent, shamanistic times.

4. The chopping down of macanilla and other palms to make instruments and harvest wild fruits is the first activity of all sacred rites and ceremonies.

5. I worked primarily with a chant-owner from the Dzáwinai phratry and have little comparative data for determining how much variation exists between the metaphors employed by different specialists. Listening to tapes of a chant-owner from the Hohódeni phratry in Brazil has revealed that the same principles of naming are employed in widely separate areas of Wakuénai territory. Much like the Kuna chiefly chanters described by Sherzer (1983), Wakuénai chant-owners' reputation and prestige is partially based on their abilities to create and use multivocal metaphors.

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